Week 3: Literary Styles in the Bible

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The Bible isn't written in one uniform style — tonight we'll look at a few of the different kinds of writing it uses, and what changes once you notice which one you're in.

1. Think about how differently you read a novel, a poem, and a set of assembly instructions — you don't expect any of them to work the same way, even though they're all just words on a page. When you open the Bible, do you read it with that same shifting awareness, or more like one undifferentiated block of text?

2. Narrative makes up nearly half of the Bible. Why do you think God chose to reveal so much of himself through story, rather than through straightforward teaching or a list of rules?

3. **Read Jonah 1.** This chapter is narrative — a character (Jonah), a setting (a ship fleeing to Tarshish), and a mounting conflict (the storm). Who does most of the chapter's action actually center on after verse 3, and how do they respond to what's happening?

4. Jonah is running from God's call to preach to Nineveh, a city Israel hated. By the end of the chapter, the pagan sailors on the ship end up looking more godly than Jonah does. What do you think the author wants us to notice by setting up that contrast?

5. **Read Jonah 2.** What does Jonah actually say in this prayer — what does he acknowledge about what's happened to him, and what does he vow to do? Jonah's prayer from inside the fish shifts from narrative into poetry. Poetry works differently than narrative — it's meant to be felt and imagined, not just informed. What images or phrases stand out to you here, and how do they land differently than if this moment had just been described in plain narration?

6. Jonah is about to storm off in anger at God again just two chapters later, after Nineveh repents. Does his prayer in chapter 2 sound to you like genuine repentance, or something else? What do you make of that tension?

7. **Read Romans 8:1-4 and 8:31-39.** What does Paul say is now true for those who are in Christ Jesus, and what does he list that can't separate us from the love of God? This is prose discourse — Paul building a connected, logical argument (notice words like "therefore," "because," "so that"). What is Paul actually trying to persuade his readers to believe or do in this chapter?

8. Discourse like Romans 8 is built to engage your reasoning; poetry like Jonah's prayer is built to engage your imagination and emotions. Which style do you personally connect with more easily when you read Scripture, and which one do you tend to skim past?

9. The same Bible contains a fish-swallows-a-prophet story and a dense theological argument about no condemnation and nothing separating us from God's love. How do you think these very different kinds of writing work together, rather than feeling like a mismatched grab bag?

10. If you started paying closer attention to what kind of writing you're reading — story, poem, or argument — what do you think would change about how you read Scripture, or what you'd expect to get out of it?